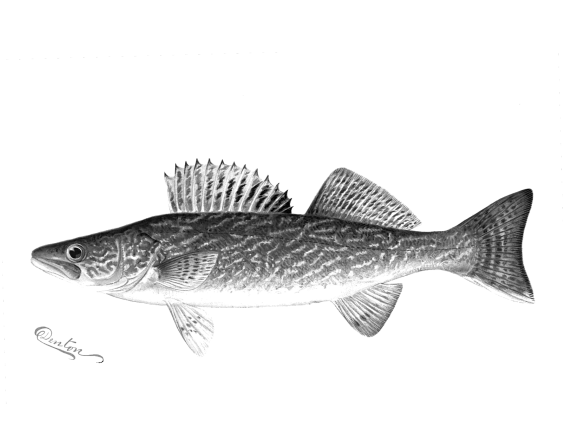


Walleye

Sander vitreus

The low-light specialist — Pine Lake & North Lake



The Pike Perch or Wall-Eyed Pike — chromolithograph by S.F. Denton, New York Commissioners of Fisheries, Game and Forests, 1896–1902. Public domain; converted to grayscale for printing.

Tell it apart

A **white tip on the lower lobe of the tail** and a dark blotch at the rear base of the spiny dorsal fin. The eye is large and glassy — a reflective layer behind the retina lets it see in water too dark for its prey. Long canine teeth.

Not a sauger

Sauger have rows of black spots on the spiny dorsal, dark saddles, and no white tail tip. Not expected here, but worth knowing.

Size here

15–22 in. The 18 in minimum means most fish you catch go back. State record 18 lb.

Spawn

Earliest of the gamefish after pike: 42–50 °F, late March into April, over rock and gravel shorelines and in inflows. Pine Lake is stocked with large fingerlings in alternate years.

Season

J	F	M	A	M	J	J	A	S	O	N	D
■	■	■	■	■	■	■	■	■	■	■	■

Time of day

Dawn	Mid	Dusk	Night
■	■	■	■

Where

Pine	Spots 3 (east wall), 4 (the bar) and 8 . In high summer they may suspend over the basin following cisco — do not assume they are on the bottom.
North	Spots 3 , 4 (south-end shoals) and 5 (the neck). Stained water means they will be shallower than on Pine.
Depth	The 18–30 ft break most of the year. Shallower at dawn, dusk and after dark; deeper in bright calm.
Weather	Grey and windy is a walleye day. Wind on a point breaks up the light and pushes bait against structure — fish the windy side.

How

Classic	Lindy rig with a leech, half a crawler, or a small minnow, dragged slowly along the contour, <i>see the lindy rig sheet</i> . Slow means slower than you think.
Cold water	Jig-and-minnow, <i>see the jig-and-minnow sheet</i> , worked with tiny lifts. Most bites feel like weight, not a strike.
Steep faces	A three-way rig holds a precise depth where a lindy rig will not, <i>see the three-way rig sheet</i> .
Timing	The last forty minutes of light beat the rest of the day. Be on the spot before the sun goes.

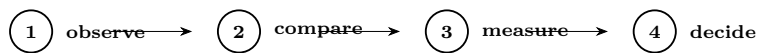
The one thing to remember

Walleye are not hard to catch; they are hard to be present for. Their eyes give them an advantage in dim light, so they feed when you would rather be at the landing. Fish the edges of the day.

Worth knowing

The eye is the whole fish	The <i>tapetum lucidum</i> is a reflective layer behind the retina that bounces light back through it a second time. It gives a walleye roughly a full order of magnitude of light advantage over the perch it hunts — and it is why the fish avoids bright sun, not because it dislikes it but because in daylight the advantage disappears.
So fish the light, not the clock	Dawn, dusk, night, a chop on the water, a cloudy front, stained water: all the same thing to a walleye. On Pine Lake's very clear water the effect is exaggerated, which is why the bite window there is narrow and worth being present for.
Growth	Females grow considerably faster and larger than males. Nearly every walleye over 24 in is a female. In this part of the state an 18 in fish is roughly four to six years old.
Stocked, not self-sustaining	Pine Lake receives large fingerling walleye in alternate years. That is a strong hint that natural reproduction is limited here — the population is a managed one, and the size structure reflects stocking years.
They travel at night	Radio-tracking on similar lakes shows walleye moving substantial distances after dark, up onto flats they never visit in daylight. The fish that was not on your break at noon may be in 8 ft of water at eleven at night.

Prove it in hand



Ask first	Is the white tip confined to the lower tail lobe, with a dark blotch at the rear of the first dorsal?
Rule out	Sauger lack the white tip and carry rows of spots across the spiny dorsal; do not decide from the glassy eye.
Measure	Close the mouth, pinch the tail only if the rule says to, and read total length against a rigid board: close the toothed mouth against the stop and keep fingers clear of gill plates.
Field proof	White tail tip and dorsal blotch must both be visible. Photograph the whole side profile and the decisive feature before release if the identification remains uncertain.

Regulations on these waters, 2026–27. 18 in minimum, 3 per day, open 2 May–7 March. *These change; only the Wisconsin DNR's current publication for this exact water body is authoritative.*

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